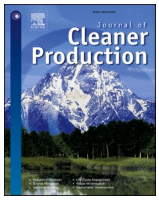
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Promoting sustainable agri-food systems through sustainability and responsible marketing: The case of peruvian companies at international trade shows

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ABSTRACT

For companies in the agri-food sector, sustainability marketing represents a strategic tool, insofar as it enables companies to achieve sustainability in their production and commercial processes, while, at the same time, exerting a fundamental influence on their reputation. This study raises the following research questions: How do agri-food exporting companies view sustainability marketing and its practical application? To which aspects of their sustainable marketing system do such companies attach greater or lesser importance? Using a constructive research approach, a study was carried out by conducting interviews with experts in the sector, as well as with managers from agrifood export companies. On the basis of such interviews, an analytical framework as well as an accessible management tool comprising 17 variables (grouped into 6 sets) are proposed to support the management of sustainability marketing by companies in the agri-food sector. The results indicate that companies prioritized strategies linked to the certification of their production systems and their quality, as well as logistical capacity, environmental certifications, and commitment to climate change and fairtrade principles. Among the aspects they attach less importance, the ones related to distribution systems stand out. These results serve as a basis to support the managers of agri-food exporting companies in developing more sustainable agri-food systems through the appropriate and comprehensive use of sustainability marketing. A recommendation further arises for companies to align their sustainability marketing strategies with their market positioning, in order to support both their reputation and their competitive advantages.

1. Introduction

In modern-day society where the term sustainability is now common currency, the day-to-day activities of many organizations address sustainability, and environmental goals and initiatives (Saulick et al., 2023). Meeting targets and performance can have decisive impacts both on their reputation (Gomez-Trujillo et al., 2020) and on current and potential results (Bhattacharyya, 2023). It is therefore essential to understand how companies design systems and implement strategies to promote sustainability through cleaner production (Sharma et al., 2023), efficient supply chains (Jamalnia et al., 2023), and sustainable consumption (Hansen, 2021), and to provide them with useful tools to do so (Doernberg et al., 2022). Among such tools, sustainability marketing emerges as one of the most relevant (Thu and Tho, 2023), given the key role of the marketing function for both business sustainability (Tollin and Christensen, 2019) and the promotion of inter-organizational cooperation to protect the environment (Business-to-Business (B2B marketing), and sustainable consumer behavior (Business-to-Consumer marketing) (Jia et al., 2022).

Taking Stakeholder Theory as a reference, sustainability marketing is regarded as a more advanced and responsible version of marketing (Dangelico and Vocalelli, 2017), in which the needs of the various stakeholders and their interactions through trade are considered, as well as their environmental and social impacts (Demartini et al., 2023). Sustainability marketing is now a crucial issue in the agri-food sector, given its international economic relevance, as well as its significant influence on public health and environmental protection, through such issues as waste disposal (Govindan et al., 2023a), the promotion of sustainable consumption (Saba et al., 2019), and socially and environmentally responsible behavior (Kumari et al., 2022).

From a market-oriented management perspective (Ćorić et al., 2020), sustainability marketing emerges within the agri-food area as an

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association between economic, technological, social, and environmental aspects of business relations, and the sustainable development of the agri-food system (Freidberg, 2023). In consequence, guided by the principles of the Resource-Based Theory (Kozlenkova et al., 2014), sustainability marketing provides agri-food organizations with the capacity to develop sustainable competitive advantages (Aghazadeh et al., 2022). A capacity that is enhanced through circular-economy systems that reduce the overall environmental impact of companies working to achieve their goals (Demartini et al., 2023) and, if in receipt of government support, to develop sustainability strategies (Govindan and Hasanagic, 2018).

A key issue when developing competitive advantage through sustainability marketing is to consider its potential effect on both company reputation (Binu Raj et al., 2022) and consumer purchase intention (Sharma and Kaur, 2021). It is particularly relevant at the start of a business relation when new agri-food products are promoted on the market (Doorn et al., 2021), due to informational asymmetries, which make it difficult *a priori* to assess either seller reputation or product quality (Abrate and Viglia, 2019). It is likewise difficult for all stakeholders to invest high levels of commitment in a very recently initiated business relation (Suvanto and Lähdesmäki, 2023). The same may be said of business relations within B2B markets where economic transactions of large volumes and magnitude are often formalized (Casidy and Lie, 2023).

In such circumstances, the key factors that might support the reputational assessment of an agri-food company are of particular interest: social responsibility (Castilla-Polo et al., 2017), the transparency of its public information (Ferri et al., 2023), its innovative tendencies (Latino et al., 2023), the sustainability of its objectives (Quintana-García et al. 2022), management resource systems (Gascón et al., 2023), and strategies (Lukason and Vissak, 2019), amongst others.

In summary, sustainability marketing in the agri-food context encompasses both the activities and the resources of companies, as well as their outputs that are generated through the commercialization of agri-food products, and the corporate social responsibilities that may arise from such activities (Lunde, 2018; Pomering, 2017), due to their high impact on the sustainability of agri-food systems (Nath and Siepong, 2022). Hence, the great importance and complexity of sustainability marketing. However, as outlined below, significant gaps persist within that area that are addressed in the current paper.

Firstly, most studies on sustainability marketing have been focused on partial aspects, with limited research covering all stages of the agri-food system (Kumari et al., 2022; Pomering, 2017). In contrast, the present study adopts a holistic approach (Lunde, 2018), incorporating economic, technological, relational, and ethical aspects of its production, distribution, and communication, as well as social and environmental facets (Nagaty, 2022).

Secondly, sustainability marketing has not been addressed in sufficient depth in the field of agri-food products (Dangelico and Vocalelli, 2017; McDonagh and Prothero, 2014), something that has hindered both a uniform definition (Kemper and Ballantine, 2019), and its usage in agri-food business practice (Dowling, 2016; Kar and Harichandan, 2022).

Thirdly, the multiple connotations of the agri-food sector make it necessary to adapt sustainability marketing measures to the particular context in which they may be applied (Isaak et al., 2021a; Legun and Marion, 2018). It therefore creates a need for specific tools, as it is both difficult and inaccurate to assess sustainability marketing and reputation in the agri-food sector through standard measures (Horn and Wagner, 2020; Dangelico and Vocalelli, 2017).

In line with the research gaps identified above, the central objective and main contribution of this research has been to conceptualize and to formulate a framework that integrates the most relevant characteristics and strategies of sustainability marketing for agri-food companies, in order to promote its operationalization and functional use in business activity. As part of the proposed framework, it is suggested in this paper that, beyond sustainable production processes, additional business aspects of agri-food product management as well as organizational and stakeholder sustainability should also be considered. It would also imply taking into consideration production and operations management from a sustainable perspective, with a strong focus on supply chain issues and sustainable supplier collaboration (Govindan and Jha, 2024).

The approach presented in this paper is framed within Institutional Theory, which emphasizes the importance of implementing business practices -such as sustainabilty marketing-that reinforce the reputation of a business -its legitimacy-within its environment (Ebrahimi and Koh, 2021). In that sense, it should be noted that responsible and sustainable business practice among agri-food companies is increasingly welcomed among consumers of agri-food products, who are demanding not only green technologies for their production (Kumari et al., 2022), but also aspects such as brand legitimacy (Czinkota et al., 2014; Liu and Dong, 2021), sustainable retail chains that optimally reallocate resources (Gupta et al., 2023; Yousefi-Babadi et al., 2023), sustainable suppliers (Bai et al., 2023), business ethics (Peterson et al., 2021), food safety (Civero et al., 2017; Su et al., 2022), and quality certifications (Hou et al., 2023).

The relevance of context in the development of reputation has also been considered (Fombrum, 2012; Nagaty, 2022). In particular, the sector under study, the agri-food export sector, and company participation in international Business-to-Business (B2B) trade shows, is one in which reputation plays a fundamental role. The main reasons for this selection are outlined below.

First, international trade shows (each driven by an Export Promotion Agency -EPA) through which to promote agri-food exports (Makioka, 2021) are essential, in so far as they encourage interaction between companies, whether buying or selling (Rinallo et al., 2017), and enhance B2B contacts, connections, and commercial networks (Vitali et al., 2022). The criticality of international trade shows is evident in the strategic value that companies say they have for enhancing their business performance (Brown et al., 2017; Khongsawatkiat and Agmapisarn, 2023).

Second, the results of previous studies have demonstrated that trade shows constitute powerful channels through which both the reputation and the business image of the participant companies can be improved. It is an approach that is linked to the theoretical foundations of relationship marketing, because of the importance of interactions for reinforcing engagement in B2B markets (Casidy and Lie, 2023). At the same time, the key role of reputation within the agri-food sector is evident in the selection of companies participating in these international trade shows. Consequently, sustainability marketing in this context emerges as a strategic tool to build a solid and reliable green and sustainability-based reputation, facilitating both participation in those sorts of events and driving agri-food company exports. Research is limited within the area (Gopalakrishna et al., 2019; Silva, 2021), which in turn reveals a research gap and an opportunity that is addressed in the current study.

With that purpose in mind, research has been conducted on Peruvian companies participating in international trade shows. The interesting issue of sustainability marketing within the socio-economic and cultural context of Peru and its agri-food sector is worth noting. Moreover, the sector has hardly been studied, despite its importance to the Peruvian economy. Specifically, the agri-food sector is the most dynamic export sector in Peru, representing almost 25% of total exports (ranked second, after the mining sector), with 2322 agro-export companies exporting 601 products to 142 markets. In addition, Peru is a leading international exporter of certain agri-food products, such as blueberries, quinoa, ginger, grapes, mangoes, cocoa and coffee beans, among others (Ministry of Foreign Trade and Tourism of Peru, 2022; PROMPERU, 2020).

In short, the research approach in the current study is based on the consideration of sustainability marketing as one of the factors currently exerting the most significant influence on the sustainability reputation of agri-food export companies. Sustainability reputation has positive impacts on business performance (Saulick et al., 2023) and the

opportunities for companies within the sector to participate at strategic events, such as trade shows (Khongsawatkiat and Agmapisarn, 2023), as well as for consumers and society (Jia et al., 2022). Thus, companies should develop sustainable production and marketing processes for their agri-food products, based on innovative and resource-efficient green technologies that can contribute to curbing climate change (Latino et al., 2023; Legun and Marion, 2018), and which will, ultimately, increase the sustainability of agri-food systems (Li et al., 2020; Sarabia et al., 2021).

The gaps identified in the field of sustainability marketing strategies for agri-food products are as follows: the need for a homogeneous conceptualization, the limited number of specific studies applying a global perspective, and the need for operational tools to support companies with the design and implementation of sustainability marketing strategies adapted to specific contexts. Furthermore, the decisive influence of sustainability marketing on company reputation and the sustainability of agri-food systems has been noted. All of the above points lead us to raise the following research questions and subsequent objectives:

RQ1: What strategies, actions, and resources should agri-food companies implement and use to develop sustainability marketing that is appropriate to their context and sector?
RQ2: In practice, to which aspects of sustainability marketing strategies do agri-food companies attach greater or lesser importance?

The main contributions of the present study are linked to its two primary objectives. The first research question is linked to the first objective of this study: to provide an integrated perspective on sustainability marketing in the agri-food sector. With respect to that objective, a management perspective is adopted in the study to put forth a comprehensive sustainability marketing framework for agri-food exporting companies. It supports the design and implementation of company marketing strategies (actions and resources), thereby adding further opportunities to impact on overall business performance. The analytical framework presented in the first stage of the current study reflects the dual contribution of both the researchers (through an extensive literature review) and the experts from organizations based in different countries within the sector (Export Promotion Agencies, Trade Associations, and International Organizations).

With respect to the study's second objective (namely to categorize the relative importance attributed to each component of sustainability marketing identified in the first stage), marketing and export managers from 30 Peruvian agri-food export companies were interviewed. The information collected through that process represents the second most important overall contribution of this research, in that it provides valuable information on the vision and priorities of the participating companies. It then led to the detection of areas for improvement and areas of strength with respect to the sustainability of their systems, upon which their reputation is built.

In the following sections, a conceptual review is provided of corporate reputation, sustainability marketing, and the export of agri-food products through international B2B trade shows, which taken together, represent the conceptual basis of our research. It is followed by a description of the methodology used in the empirical study, and a discussion of its results and related conclusions. Finally, managerial implications for the sustainability of agri-food systems are highlighted, as well as areas for improvement and further research.

2. Corporate reputation of agri-food companies

Corporate reputation is recognized as an intangible strategic asset, capable of both contributing to the current and future performance and profitability of agri-food companies (Saulick et al., 2023), and providing them with advantageous positions over competitors (Nagaty, 2022), given its influence on how their products are perceived and valued in markets. Thus, customers are more likely to attach high value to agri-food products from companies with favourable reputations (Barnett and Leih, 2018; Kumari et al., 2022), which are perceived as socially responsible (Civero et al., 2017).

In view of the importance of corporate reputation, agri-food companies have optimized their corporate reputation management strategies (Castilla-Polo et al., 2017), among which agri-food exporters provide some of the most relevant examples (Aghazadeh et al., 2022).

Considering the multidimensionality of the reputation construct, numerous authors have proposed definitions of business reputation, adopting varying points of view and methodologies (Money et al., 2017; Khan and Digout, 2018). The current perspective of corporate reputation, Stakeholder Theory, highlights the significant impact of reputation on short-term performance, and most importantly on the perceptions, beliefs, emotions, and feelings that stakeholders associate with companies during their business relationships (Hur et al., 2020; Martos-Pedrero et al., 2022).

In the context of the above-mentioned relationships, the environmental and social sustainability components of agri-food systems can assume great relevance and can even become unavoidable issues, not only in agri-food business strategies (Lukason and Vissak, 2019; Quintana-García et al., 2022), but also in company ethical codes (Luhmann and Theuvsen, 2016; Castilla-Polo et al., 2017).

One of the main reasons for the relevance of those components is that consumers of agri-food products make purchase decisions on the basis of price criteria, while also considering ethical, environmental, and employment issues (Civero et al., 2017). Indeed, sustainability and environmental protection are essential considerations in the main international corporate reputation rankings: the Reputation Quotient (RQ), developed in 1999 by Charles Fombrun in cooperation with Harris Interactive Inc.; World's Most Admired Companies (WMAC), published by Fortune Magazine since 1997; and MERCO (Monitor Empresarial de Reputación Corporativa) in Spain and Latin America (Ferri et al., 2023; Fombrum and Ponzi, 2015; Horn and Wagner, 2020).

3. Sustainability marketing and Corporate Reputation

In the current economic and social environment, agri-food companies need to contribute to sustainability so that they are perceived in that way (Jia et al., 2022; Lankoski, 2016). To do so, sustainability marketing constitutes an essential tool that responds to social, ethical, and environmental concerns (Kemper and Ballantine, 2019), promoting organizational sustainable development (Ćorić et al., 2020) that is compatible with the company performance and reputation (Lucic, 2020; Nagaty, 2022). From a social responsibility perspective, Lunde (2018) referred to sustainability marketing as strategies and actions that increase the quality of life of customers, by reducing damage to the environment, and thereby achieving a balance for future generations.

Table 1 shows a chronological list of the different definitions of sustainability marketing, providing insight into its conceptualization over the years.

The above definitions constitute an interesting conceptual frame of reference for agri-food companies that wish to develop sustainability marketing strategies, and to improve their corporate reputation, insofar as the definitions reveal the main aspects and dimensions of the concept as it developed. However, companies require further specific information, appropriate to their environment and circumstances, to design and to implement efficient sustainability marketing strategies (Bhattacharyya, 2023). Specifically, sustainability marketing and the green technologies that are associated with it must cover all stages of both the development and the marketing of agri-food products. It therefore encompasses issues related to production methods and resource consumption (Kar and Harichandan, 2022), transport routes, supplier systems (Govindan and Jha, 2024), and local development and social equilibrium (Suvanto and Lähdesmäki, 2023).

In addition, these products must incorporate packaging and labels made with green materials and technologies (Hou et al., 2023).

Table 1
Conceptualization of sustainability marketing.

Definition	Authors
Sustainable marketing is an appeal to accept the ecological and social limitations of the conventional corporate marketing philosophy.	Van Dam and Apeldoorn (1996)
Sustainable marketing is an integral approach that places emphasis on environmental, social equity, and economic/financial concerns for the development of marketing strategies.	Bridges and Wilhelm (2008)
Sustainability marketing is building and maintaining sustainable relationships with customers, the social environment, and the natural environment, by adopting an intergenerational perspective of the sustainable development agenda.	Peattie and Belz (2010)
Sustainable Market Orientation (SMO): sustainable marketing is supported by three sustainability management constructs: social, environmental, and economic corporate responsibilities.	Mitchell et al. (2010)
Sustainability marketing incorporates economic, social, and environmental dimensions.	Kumar et al. (2013)
The objectives of sustainability marketing are: 1. Sustainable development; 2. Survival of the organization - profit (economic sustainability); 3. Survival of the environment (environmental sustainability); 4. Survival of society (societal sustainability).	Rakic and Rakic (2015)
Framework for Sustainability Marketing with five dimensions: globalized marketplace of value exchange, responsible environmental behavior, equitable sustainable-business-practices, ethical sustainable consumption, quality-of-life and well-being.	Lunde (2018)
Auxiliary Sustainability Marketing focuses on the production of sustainable products by integrating sustainability throughout the marketing mix. Reformational Sustainability Marketing extends the auxiliary approach through the promotion of sustainable lifestyles and behavioural changes, considering that current levels of consumption are unsustainable. Transformative Sustainability Marketing extends both the auxiliary and transformative approaches through the transformation of current institutions and norms and critical reflection.	Kemper and Ballantine (2019)
Sustainability marketing is a holistic concept that prioritizes the well-being of consumers and the environment through the production, consumption and disposal of environmentally friendly products and services.	Nagaty (2022)

Source: Authors' own compilation based on the literature.

Likewise, the technologies and materials used for commercial communications must be environmentally friendly (Chugh et al., 2016). Finally, the supply chain and its significant potential effect on the environment must be based on green processes, systems, and technologies (Govindan, 2023), involving all actors in the chain: manufacturers, intermediaries (suppliers and distributors), and final customers (Gupta et al., 2023).

Ultimately, a truly sustainable marketing strategy must be based on agri-food products obtained with sustainable and environmentally friendly technologies, which also meet all quality and safety requirements both for consumers and for society (Shi et al., 2022).

4. Agri-food exports through international business-to-business trade shows

International B2B trade shows represent one of the main means of promoting agri-food exports, with the reputation of the company being of enormous relevance, in order to be eligible to participate in them (Jha et al., 2019; Vitali et al., 2022). Among the effects that companies participating in this type of event pursue, the promotion of new activities, relationship marketing actions, the improvement of corporate image, and commercial sales initiatives (Brown et al., 2017; Getz and Page, 2019) all stand out.

Trade shows are effective vehicles for promoting trade among exporters (Makioka, 2021), enabling exchange and networking between visitors, exhibitors, organizers, suppliers, producers, distributors, associations, and other organizations (Mora Cortez et al., 2022; Tafesse and Skallerud, 2016). Specifically, their main functions are to provide a venue for business contacts between buyers and suppliers, to generate information on industry and market trends, to distribute products within other markets, to gain visibility, and to establish business partners (Sarmento et al., 2015; United Nations UNIDO, 2019).

The economic impact of trade shows is considered highly significant for the companies that participate in them (Khongsawatkiat and Agmapisarn, 2023). At the same time, both the quality (based largely on the reputations of the participating companies) and the quantity of exhibitors also reflect the reputation of a trade show (Association of the German Trade Fair Industry, 2021; UFI, Oxford UFIOxford Economics, 2022).

Given the link between a company's reputation and its options for participating in international trade shows, sustainability marketing becomes particularly relevant for agri-food exporting companies, insofar as it enhances the company's reputation through the elements of sustainability, environmental protection, and an appropriate use of green technologies and resources (Gopalakrishna et al., 2019; Silva, 2021). Hence the importance of developing sustainability marketing applications within that context.

Building on the above, the current study is focused on sustainability marketing within the specific context of B2B commercial relations, in which strong relational and trust-building components prevail, which are, in turn, essential for both the development and the consolidation of positioning, based on sustainability and commitment (Casidy and Lie, 2023). Trade shows where importers and exporters meet, exchange information, negotiate and schedule agendas, provide a useful context for this study.

5. Materials and methods

With the aim of addressing the research questions and objectives raised in this study, a constructive research approach was adopted (Hyötyläinen et al., 2014), which combined the analysis of a real-world problem (thereby contributing to business practices) with a substantive grounding in existing theoretical research (Lukka, 2003; Yin, 2018). To that end, a preliminary list of the key elements of sustainability marketing was drawn up after an extensive literature review. In all, 9 experts from Export Promotion Agencies, Trade Associations, and International Organizations from Germany, Japan, Italy, China, Belgium, Brazil, Costa Rica and Peru, were interviewed, so as to supplement and to validate that list and to provide a qualitative analysis. Specifically, the experts were contacted in the context of 3 international food-related trade shows (Cocoa and Chocolate Show and Expoalimentaria in Peru, and Anuga in Germany) held in 2021.

The experts were questioned on the aspects that in their opinions were decisive drivers of sustainability marketing and the reputation of agri-food export companies. Their views and perspectives were obtained through in-depth online interviews, given the restrictions associated with COVID-19 that were in force at the time of the study. Specifically, the experts were asked to evaluate the comprehensive list of preliminary factors developed from the literature review, on a 7-point scale. The items selected for inclusion in the final list were those that scored "high" or "very high", equivalent to an average score of over 5 points on the scale. A second round of qualitative meetings reconfirmed the conceptual structure (Madsen and Petermans, 2020).

In the second phase of the study, the export and marketing managers of 30 Peruvian agri-food companies were interviewed during 5 international trade shows (3 online in 2021- the Cocoa and Chocolate Show and Expoalimentaria in Peru, and Anuga in Germany -, and 2 face-to-face in 2022 - Cocoa and Chocolate, in Peru, and Biofach, in Germany). The company managers were contacted for interviews before the start of the different events. The importance of their participation in the

study was explained to them, but without explicitly revealing the specific objectives of the study, so as not to influence their answers. Subsequently, during the trade shows, those same managers were interviewed directly, asking them to assess the level of importance for each proposed sustainability marketing variable on a 7-point scale, with 1 representing minimum importance and 7 representing maximum importance. During the interviews, their questions were answered, and their comments were taken into consideration, but without influencing their responses. The companies marketed the following products (Table 2):

6. Results

With regard to the first research question, 17 sustainability marketing variables were identified in the study, which have an impact on both the reputation of agri-food export companies and the sustainability of the agri-food system. Those variables were grouped into 6 sets: information systems and communication, distribution systems, product characteristics, human resources of the company, financial resources, and social elements of the environment (Table 3):

As indicated above, the sets of sustainability-marketing variables reflect the sustainable marketing-mix strategies of the companies: communication, distribution, and product (Sets 1, 2 and 3). Moreover, sustainability marketing was linked to the internal balance of company resources, both human and financial (Sets 4 and 5), and to several key social issues (Set 6): climate change, real commitment to sustainability, fair trade and social justice.

Regarding the second research question, the average scores for each sustainability marketing variable (assessed through interviews with 30 managers responsible for food exports and international marketing strategies) are shown below (Figs. 1 and 2).

As can be observed above in Figs. 1 and 2, the average scores range between 3.9 points (approximately the average value of the scale) to 6.7 points (very close to the maximum value of the scale). The sustainability marketing components that stand out because of their scores (values over 6 points) pertain to two aspects of the sustainability marketing strategy of agri-food export companies, related to certifications (products, social and environmental) and logistics capacity. In other words, they relate to objective elements that convey a reliable sustainability reputation to stakeholders. Two social elements, namely involvement in climate change and fair trade, also received high scores.

Variables with scores above 5, but below 6 points, are placed in a second group of relative importance. Two refer to the product strategy (quality, safety, and lifetime of the products), and the other two to the financial aspects of the company (background of current exports and financial solvency). The human resources dimension, as well as the ethical dimension, also stand out, related to female employment and greenwashing, respectively.

Items that received the lowest relative scores were grouped into two categories. The first category included elements with an assigned importance of between 4.4 and 4.6 points, reflecting aspects of company communication and information systems (CSR campaigns and environmental reports of the company), product distribution (supplier environmental policy), and social aspects (impact on communities). The second category included two items that were assigned the lowest level of importance (3.9 points in both cases), both of which represented qualitative aspects of a company's structure, namely employee satisfaction and the company code of ethics.

Ranking the elements that comprised the 6 sets of variables that were identified and calculating the average score of each set also yielded some interesting results (Table 4).

As shown above in Table 4, the higher scores of certain individual items stood out within each set and were therefore perceived as being of greater importance to sustainability marketing. Those items are as follows: within the information and communication systems set: certifications of social and environmental aspects; within the distribution set: logistics capacity; within the product characteristics set: quality certifications; within the human resources set: promotion of female employment; within the financial resources set: the exporting background, although with little difference with respect to financial solvency; and within the social and ethical aspects set: the commitment to climate change and fair trade.

Finally, the overall set of factors that received the highest average score was product characteristics, followed by social and ethical elements, financial resources, and distribution systems. As groups of factors of the least importance, company human resources stood out, closely followed by the communication of information to the outside world.

Table 2
Agri-food products commercialized by the companies taking part in the survey.

Product category	Specific products
Fruits and vegetables	Blueberry, goldenberry, purple corn, ginger, chia, camu-camu, lucuma, maca, yacon, amaranth, sacha inchi, oregano
Frozen Products	Grape, strawberry, mango, avocado
Dehydrated Products	Mango, banana, aguaymanto, papaya, pineapple
Juices and Nectars	Cranberry juice, lemon juice, grape juice, fruit drinks
Cocoa	Cocoa nibs, cocoa beans, chocolate coating, cocoa paste, cocoa butter
Cocoa derivatives	Chocolate-covered cranberries, chocolate-covered almonds
Quinoa	White, red, black
Flours	Organic artichoke flour
Spices	Turmeric, annatto
Pulses	Beans
Coffee	Coffee beans

7. Discussion and conclusions

The results obtained in the first phase of the present study support the identification of a series of strategic elements, grouped into 6 management areas, that should be used to guide agri-food export companies towards better design and implementation of their sustainability marketing strategies.

This finding represents one of the main contributions of this research, which is to provide a structured view of sustainability marketing (from the perspective of both researchers and industry experts), which also enables it to be operationalized in business practice.

In this way, the identification of 3 global dimensions (economic, social and environmental) in previous research (listed in Table 1) has progressed to the definition of specific key elements that should be incorporated into the sustainable business strategies of agri-food exporting companies. In short, it contributes to reducing two gaps: one related to the lack of conceptualization of sustainability marketing, and the other that refers to the difficulty of connecting the theoretical approaches to sustainability marketing with the reality of companies.

Furthermore, this study has been framed in an area of paramount importance in the agri-food sector: exports within B2B markets. Therefore, the support tool for the management of sustainability marketing is adapted to the particularities of this sector, with the aim of promoting its sustainability. This represents another remarkable contribution of this research, which responds to the need for studies on the sustainability of marketing in specific sectors, such as textiles (Fuxman et al., 2022; Govindan, 2023), fashion (Olson, 2022), tourism (Abrate and Viglia, 2019; Míguez et al., 2023), and agri-food (Aghazadeh et al., 2022; Isaak et al., 2021a, 2021b).

The sets of factors (sustainability marketing strategies) identified and codified in this research demonstrate a clear correspondence with current sustainability-marketing-related research trends, as illustrated in Bhattacharyya (2023), reinforcing its validity. Specifically, the information and communication systems, and human resources sets are linked to the ongoing line of research into public health marketing and informing public policy, corporate social responsibility and corporate ethics (Nagaty, 2022); the distribution systems set is framed within the

Table 3
Sustainability marketing variables (identified in first phase of the study).

Set 1: Information and communication systems
Company compliance with environmental reporting and disclosure policy
International certifications related to social and environmental aspects
Impact of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) campaigns
Company code of ethics
Set 2: Distribution systems
Supplier policy on environmental protection
Logistics capacity (prompt supply and delivery of products)
Set 3: Product characteristics
Health-care products and quality ingredients (immunological, quality of life, fresh, natural, no sugar, little or no processing, organic, *etc.*)
Product lifetime (shelf life)
International product certifications (good manufacturing practices, product quality, international standards)
Set 4: Human resources
Employee satisfaction
Policies for the promotion of female employment
Set 5: Financial resources
Financial solvency of the company
Background of current exports (current volume and capacity of company exports)
Set 6: Contextual social elements
Awareness of climate change
Perception of 'greenwashing'
Implementation of fair-trade principles
Impact on communities

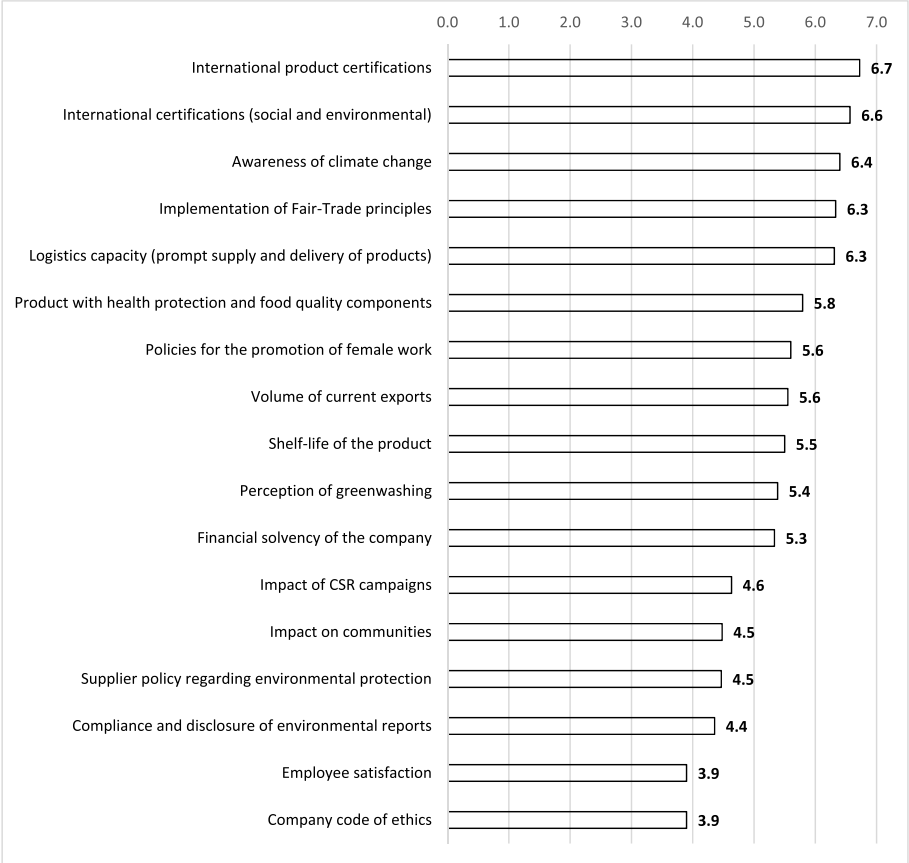


Fig. 1. Ranking and rating (average values) across all sustainability elements. Results of the survey of export managers (on a scale of 1-to-7 points). Source: Authors' own work.

trends of green marketing strategies (Gupta et al., 2023; Yousefi-Babadi et al., 2023); the product characteristics set is the focus of several current lines of study, in particular public health and promoting healthy lifestyles (Segovia-Villareal and Rosa-Diaz, 2022); and finally, the social elements of the context set is directly linked to the lines of research on social marketing for behavioural and positive social change (Demartini et al., 2023).

Similarly, the sets of sustainability marketing components that have been defined in this study fit perfectly with the vision of sustainability marketing as an association between environmental issues (green strategies and technologies in product development and distribution and communication systems), economic elements (financial support), and ethical and relational aspects (social elements and human resources), which support the implementation of sustainable agri-food development

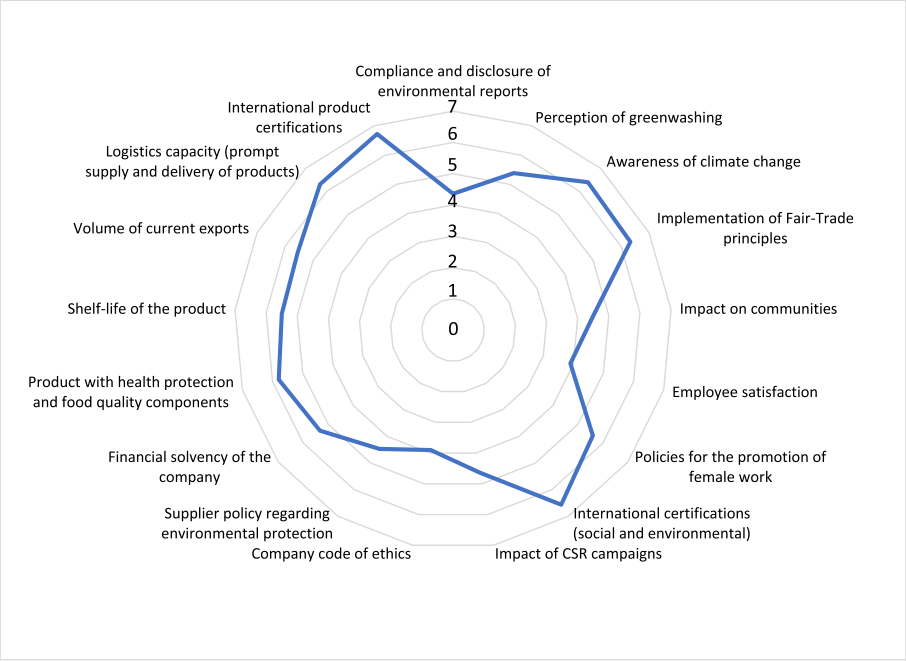


Fig. 2. Results of the survey of export managers (spider graph). Source: Authors' own work.

Table 4
Importance of sustainability marketing variables by sets.

Set 1: Information and communication systems (mean value = 4.88)	
International certifications related to social and environmental aspects	6.6
Impact of CSR campaigns	4.6
Company compliance and disclosure of environmental reports	4.4
Company code of ethics	3.9
Set 2: Distribution systems (mean value = 5.40)	
Logistics capacity (prompt supply and delivery of product)	6.3
Supplier policy on environmental protection	4.5
Set 3: Product characteristics (mean value = 6.25)	
International product certifications (good manufacturing practices, product quality, international standards)	6.7
Product with health protection and food quality components (immunological, quality of life, fresh, natural without sugar, little processing, organic, *etc*.)	5.8
Lifetime of the product (time shelf)	5.5
Set 4: Human resources (mean value = 4.75)	
Policies for the promotion of female work	5.6
Employee satisfaction	3.9
Set 5: Financial resources (mean value = 5.45)	
Background of current exports (volume of current exports of the company. capacity)	5.6
Financial solvency of the company	5.3
Set 6: Social and ethical elements (mean value = 5.65)	
Awareness of climate change	6.4
Implementation of fair-trade principles	6.3
Perception of greenwashing	5.4
Impact on communities	4.5

systems (Ćorić et al. 2020; Doernberg et al. 2022).

An additional major contribution of this study has been to provide insight into the priorities of the participating agri-food exporting companies with regard to sustainability marketing strategies which, as established in Resource-Based Theory (Kozlenkova et al., 2014), support the development of their sustainable competitive advantages (Aghazadeh et al., 2022). It therefore offers an understanding of the strategic approach of the agri-food export sector in B2B markets. According to the results, the primary orientation of their sustainability marketing objectives appears to be towards achieving international certifications for agri-food exports. A finding in line with previous research, which highlights the elements that transmit an image of sustainability to the environment (Hou et al., 2023). Within the specific context of this study, those results may be further enhanced in view of the demanding reputation-related requirements for participation in major international trade shows (Bonisoli et al., 2019; Khongsawatkiat and Agmapisarn, 2023).

Green technologies have a vital role to play to attain international certifications related to social and environmental aspects (Hansen, 2021). An opinion that is corroborated by the findings of the present study, which highlight the great importance that companies attach to awareness of climate change, a factor for which environmentally friendly technologies are of paramount importance (Isaak et al., 2021b). However, the real environmental commitment that accompanies the use of green technologies was not observed with the same intensity in other aspects of the sustainability marketing strategies of the participating companies, contrary to the recommendations of researchers within this area (Sharma et al., 2023; Shi et al., 2022).

Particularly noteworthy is the result related to the distribution of agricultural products, for which logistical capacity (prompt supply and delivery of products) is clearly afforded greater importance than supplier policy on environmental protection (6.4 and 4.5 points respectively). Clearly established in the literature, this strong emphasis on logistics capacity (Gupta et al., 2023) represents a key factor, if supply chains are to achieve the much-needed efficiency for conserving agri-food product quality (Ali and Govindan, 2023). Nevertheless, as the international distribution of these products widen, the environmental effects become critical (consumption of resources, pollution, environmental footprint, *etc*.). In consequence, the design of sustainable supply chains should, although not explicitly detected in this study, be a fundamental aspect for sustainability marketing strategies.

This lack of coherence in terms of the sustainability of the agri-food distribution system constitutes a relevant finding of this research, insofar as it warns of probable reputational concerns for the companies that participate in that system (Bartels et al., 2020), as the environmental commitment signals are perceived as inconsistent in the market (Aghazadeh et al., 2022; Li et al., 2020). Based on Stakeholder Theory, agri-food exporting companies must therefore ensure the sustainability of the entire supply chain, taking into account the long distances over which agri-foods are transported from the place of origin to the destination markets (Doernberg et al., 2022; Tong et al., 2018). The challenge for companies is, therefore, to become true value-generating

supply chains, through the design of supply networks (location of facilities, modes of transport and appropriate customer service) that make cost and operational efficiency compatible with the sustainability performance of the suppliers (Govindan et al., 2023b), and the commitment to environmental and social issues (Bai et al., 2023; Gupta et al., 2023).

Achieving a sustainable agri-food system must also include communication strategies (Luhmann and Theuvsen, 2016). Specifically, it is a matter of implementing a lateral vision of sustainable communication networks, from the raw materials they incorporate and the recycling processes, to the efficient use of resources, media, and support services (Segovia-Villarreal and Rosa-Díaz, 2022). Having said as much, the specific technological aspects of the communication systems listed above were neither identified by the experts who developed the tool presented in this study, nor were they mentioned in the interviews with the managers, who were administered the questionnaire and given the opportunity to provide open comments. Weak implementations of sustainable technologies in company communication systems have also been identified in other studies (Chugh et al., 2016; Iqbal et al., 2023), which points to a fundamental opportunity for improvement in companies aiming to achieve the full sustainability of their business processes.

In short, the sustainability of the agri-food systems, based on green technologies, must be ensured not only in the production stages, but also in terms of the distribution systems and the technological communication resources that are implemented.

Another important finding of the current study was that, within their sustainability marketing strategies, participating companies attached greater importance to the strategies considered to have more direct impact on the company's public image (achieving certifications and being perceived as aware of climate change, committed to fair trade, and to the promotion of women's work, and not involved in greenwashing), as opposed to the aspects with stronger links to the green technologies of their distribution and communication systems, and to the organization's internal operating system (employee satisfaction, environmental reports and company codes of ethics). In contrast, those factors are highlighted as essential in research within this area, both for the sustainability and the reputation of agri-food companies (Gascón et al., 2023; Kelmenson, 2023). The most likely underlying reason for such results is that the participating companies considered the impact of external issues on their reputation to be greater than the impact of the factors that were more internal to the organization (Bartels et al., 2020; Imbrogiano and Nichols, 2021), which can lead to inconsistencies in the sustainable management of their business processes (Hur et al., 2020).

Ultimately, a sustainable agri-food system must be sustainable in all its components. Accordingly, the development of sustainability marketing strategies must promote comprehensive environmental protection (including deforestation, reduction of the carbon footprint, less polluting and more resource-efficient manufacturing, water use, distribution, and communication systems), and it should also include as a priority the physical and mental health of employees (Kelmenson, 2023), ethical behavior, and social welfare (De Cristofaro et al., 2023).

With regard to the social issues of the environment, it is striking how little importance is placed on the impact of agri-food company activities upon communities. It is once again short-sighted not to consider that the balance and sustainability of the agri-food system requires the consideration and inclusion of all the stakeholders: producers, distributors, consumers, and society. It is the only way to achieve a sustainable system, based on environmental care and social justice (Martos-Pedrero et al., 2022; Simmou et al., 2023),

In summary, the contributions of this study to the sustainability marketing of agri-food systems are multiple. First, a deeper conceptualization of sustainability marketing than in the context of agri-food exporting companies is offered, identifying the key strategies that comprise it (6 groups of factors). The second contribution of the study is to the operationalization of sustainability marketing through the clear identification of 17 sustainability marketing variables that can be adopted by organizations when implementing their strategies. Third, the sustainability marketing management structure is adapted to the specific context of agri-food exports in B2B markets, thus contributing to enhancing their effectiveness with respect to sustainability. Fourth, the specific study of the participating companies supports the identification of their respective strategic approaches towards developing competitive advantage, which is fundamentally based on the image they project towards external markets. Finally, key sustainability weaknesses of the agri-food export sector have been identified, which are principally linked to the management of their distribution and communication systems (production and operation management), their human resources, and their impact on communities.

The results of this study have significant managerial implications, which are in line with both the research questions and the objectives that were established at the outset.

With regard to the management of sustainability marketing by companies in the agri-food sector, the aim of the study has been to provide them with a useful and accessible management tool (RQ1-Objective 1). The results have made it possible to configure that tool, and to adapt it to the field of B2B export markets, thus contributing to the existing body of research.

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More precisely, the 6 most relevant sustainability marketing strategies to be managed by companies in the sector have been listed: product strategies, distribution systems, information systems, human factors, financial resources, and social and ethical responsibilities. The specific activities that comprise these strategies have also been detailed for companies, facilitating their structured and organized design, the establishment of short, medium, and long-term objectives for each of them, and the analysis and self-assessment of the sustainable marketing activities undertaken, as well as the resources actually used.

It also serves as a basis for company reflection and continuous improvement, through a proper and more complete understanding of the environmental, social, and economic impacts generated by their activities. This, in turn, has the potential to influence their reputation, as well as their chances of participating at trade shows, whenever that may be an important objective (Locatelli et al., 2019; Silva, 2021).

The second purpose of this study has been to discover the importance that agri-food exporting companies assign to the different sustainability marketing strategies and to the activities that comprise them (RQ2-Objective 2). The results have shown that those companies, within the sustainability marketing that they develop, prioritize strategies linked to products, and more specifically, linked to the certification of their production systems and their quality. Companies within the sector also emphasized logistical capacity and efficiency, gaining environmental certifications, and instilling commitment towards climate change and fair-trade principles.

A clear recommendation arises here for companies to align their sustainability marketing strategies with their market positioning. In particular, they should bear in mind that the priorities they set for their sustainability marketing strategies will support both their reputation and the competitive advantages they can develop.

At the same time, the aspects of sustainability marketing to which they attach less importance can become weaknesses and sources of difficulties, both for their reputation and for their profitability. Among the aspects to which less importance was attached, those related to distribution systems stand out. In that sense, it is crucial for companies within the agri-food export sector to improve their efficiency,

sustainability, and logistical capacity through issues detected in current research, such as resource reallocation (Gupta et al., 2023; Yousefi-Babadi et al., 2023), waste reduction (Gascón et al., 2023; Govindan, 2023), and the optimization of reverse logistics (Kannan et al., 2023; Münch et al., 2023).

These findings lay the foundations for companies within the sector to increase the sustainability of their commercial strategies, and for government institutions and export promotion agencies to define actions to support them, to reinforce the strengths of the sustainability marketing strategies that are identified (*i.e.*, drivers of competitive advantage), and to prioritize investment in the weaker aspects (Doernberg et al., 2022).

It should also be noted that the utility of this study is enhanced insofar as companies within other sectors can benefit from the proposed guidance and the analytical tool, as well as the sustainability-related perspective and stimulus that it provides. Further studies will be necessary to support the required adaptations to their specific contexts (sectors and circumstances).

In conclusion, companies are encouraged in this study to adopt a holistic perspective towards the development of agri-food systems, by establishing a real commitment to them through sustainable and socially responsible growth strategies (Freidberg, 2023). It all requires dialogue between all the stakeholders (Doernberg et al., 2022; Horton et al., 2016). In doing so, it is essential that companies understand the multiple dimensions of sustainability marketing, what it entails (technical and objective elements, as well as qualitative and even emotional issues), and to which specific aspects of the sustainable agri-food systems they can contribute (Dangelico and Vocalelli, 2017).

Moreover, it is not just a matter of implementing one-off sustainability marketing actions in the short term, but of integrating them into the culture of the organization as a long-term circular economy philosophy (Govindan et al., 2023a), based on balanced and sustainable (human, environmental, technological, and financial) resource usage, not only because of social responsibility, but also, because it is the only way to project a sustainable, coherent, and reliable image to society (Simmou et al., 2023).

8. Limitations and future research

A number of limitations were identified in the present study, which are proposed here as the impetus for developing new lines of research.

On one hand, the findings presented in this study are based on the views of managers of Peruvian agri-food exporting companies, which share the same economic, social, and cultural context. It is therefore important to replicate this study for companies within other economic and cultural contexts, which may allow for comparisons and for broader conclusions to be drawn, as well as for a more comprehensive understanding of the sustainability marketing strategies of agri-food companies (Ordonez-Ponce, 2023).

On the other hand, as mentioned above, the results presented in this paper are framed within the context of companies exporting agri-food products through trade shows. These companies are aware of the influence of their sustainability marketing on their reputation, as well as those aspects of their reputation that increase their chances of participating in such events (Brown et al., 2017; Khongsawatkiat and Agmapisarn, 2023). It would therefore be important to replicate this research with companies that prefer not to participate in export trade shows. In doing so, the importance that they attribute to the different aspects of sustainability marketing may be contrasted with the views of companies that regularly participate in trade shows to promote agri-food exports (Casidy and Lie, 2023; Khongsawatkiat and Agmapisarn, 2023).

In addition, green technologies constitute a necessary line of research for the development of more sustainable agri-food systems, which can be achieved through cleaner production processes (Latino et al., 2023; Sharma et al., 2023), the optimization of transport routes and the reduction of their energy consumption (Govindan et al., 2023a), the design of eco-efficient reverse logistics systems (Govindan and Bouzon, 2018; Kannan et al., 2023), and sustainable communication systems (Chugh et al., 2016; Iqbal et al., 2023), as well as local sustainable development (dosSantos and Guarnieri, 2021).

It is further proposed to incorporate qualitative methodologies (*e.g.*, case studies and in-depth interviews) for future research into the sustainability marketing of agri-food systems, in order to gain in-depth insight into the understanding within companies of the concept of sustainability, their views on the requirements for improving the sustainability of their constituent elements, their priorities, and motives (Madsen and Petermans, 2020), their difficulties (dosSantos and Guarnieri, 2021), and their principal challenges (Pohlmann et al., 2023).

It would also be of great interest to analyze the relationships between, on the one hand, the characteristics, organizational structure, and culture of companies within the sector and, on the other hand, their ways of developing and prioritizing their sustainability marketing strategies. Some ideas could be to consider their leadership models (Martos-Pedrero et al., 2022; Thu and Tho, 2023), their modes of governance (Legun and Marion, 2018; Nath and Siepong, 2022; Sarabia et al., 2021), their innovative tendencies (Latino et al., 2023), and the category of products they commercialize, *e.g.*, conventional or organic (Kar and Harichandan, 2022).

Finally, further research would also be advisable to integrate the viewpoints of the final customers of agri-food products into the sustainability marketing assessment tools of companies (Civero et al., 2017; Ferri et al., 2023).

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Manuel Puma-Flores: Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Investigation, Methodology, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. **Isabel María Rosa-Díaz:** Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Investigation, Methodology, Resources, Supervision, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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